

Pronouns and Their Antecedents

Agreement · Case · Reflexives · The Relative Family (who / whom / whose / which / that) · Clear Reference

How to use this guide

A pronoun is a stand-in word: *he, she, it, they, who, which, that*. The word it stands in for is called the **antecedent**. Almost every pronoun error in IPMAT / JIPMAT is one of five failures: the pronoun does not **match** its antecedent, it is in the wrong **case**, it is the wrong **self-form**, it is the wrong member of the **relative family**, or the reader cannot tell **what it refers to**. This guide covers all five, in that order — each rule builds on the one before it, so read in sequence.

The ladder: Read this guide → do the 10-sentence Spot Check at the end → RV02 Easy (15 Q) → RV02 Medium (15 Q) → RV02 Hard (20 Q). Score **70%+** to move up a level. Below **50%** on any test — come back to this guide before testing again.

A note on *their*: Modern English happily says "Everyone brought their book." Exams do not. In IPMAT / JIPMAT grammar questions, singular words take singular pronouns — if *his* or *her* is an option, it beats *their*. Use exam English in the exam; speak however you like outside it.

PART A · THE MATCHING GAME — Agreement

RULE 1 — A pronoun copies its antecedent: number, person, gender

Find the antecedent first. Whatever the antecedent is — singular or plural, male or female, person or thing — the pronoun must copy it exactly.

✗ Priya submitted **their** assignment early.

✓ Priya submitted **her** assignment early.

Why: One person (Priya) → one pronoun (*her*). *Their* is plural.

✗ The dog wagged **their** tail.

✓ The dog wagged **its** tail.

Why: An animal of unknown sex takes *its*.

RULE 2 — The always-singular crowd: each, either, everyone, anybody...

These words FEEL plural but are grammatically singular: **each, either, neither, one, everyone, everybody, everything, anyone, anybody, anything, someone, somebody, something, no one, nobody, nothing**. They take singular pronouns (and singular verbs — remember RV01).

✗ Everyone must carry **their** admit card.

✓ Everyone must carry **his or her** admit card.

Why: Everyone = every single one, taken one at a time.

✗ Each of the players has **their** own locker.

✓ Each of the players has **his** own locker.

Why: Each is the antecedent, not players. "Of the players" is just a photobomber — ignore it.

! GOLD TRAP

Setters love parking a plural noun between the singular word and the pronoun: "**Neither** of the sisters has finished **her** work" — not *their*. The antecedent is *neither*, never the noun inside the *of*-phrase.

RULE 3 — The always-plural four: both, few, many, several

These four are always plural — plural pronoun, plural verb. No exceptions, no moods.

✗ Several of the questions had an error in **its** options.

✓ Several of the questions had errors in **their** options.

Why: Several = more than one, always.

RULE 4 — The chameleons: some, any, none, all, most — look after the 'of'

These change colour with the noun that follows *of*. Countable noun → plural; uncountable noun → singular. (This is the opposite of Rule 2, where the *of*-phrase is ignored — that is exactly why setters mix the two in one test.)

✗ Some of the students lost **his or her** marks in Section 2.

✓ Some of the students lost **their** marks in Section 2.

Why: Students — countable, plural.

✗ All of the furniture was sold below **their** cost.

✓ All of the furniture was sold below **its** cost.

Why: Furniture — uncountable, singular.

! GOLD TRAP

None is the double agent. Traditional exam English treats it as singular ("None of the boys has done **his** work"), and that is the safer answer in IPMAT / JIPMAT. But if the options force a choice and the sense is clearly "not any of them," plural is defensible. Rule of thumb: prefer singular unless the singular option isn't offered.

RULE 5 — Collective nouns: one unit → its, separate members → their

Team, committee, jury, family, staff, audience, government — singular when acting as ONE body, plural when the members act separately. Whichever you pick, stay consistent for the whole sentence.

✗ The committee gave **their** verdict in one voice.

✓ The committee gave **its** verdict in one voice.

Why: "In one voice" = one unit.

✗ The jury are arguing among **itself**.

✓ The jury are arguing among **themselves**.

Why: Arguing = members acting separately, so plural throughout.

! GOLD TRAP

The mixed-signal sentence: "The team has won **its** match, and **they** are celebrating." Half singular, half plural — wrong either way until it is consistent. In error-spotting questions, scan the WHOLE sentence for a mid-way switch.

RULE 6 — Compound antecedents: 'and' adds up, 'or / nor' picks the nearer one

Two antecedents joined by **and** → plural pronoun. Joined by **or, nor, either...or, neither...nor** → the pronoun agrees with the antecedent **nearer** to it (the proximity rule, same as RV01).

✗ Ravi and Meera have submitted **his** project.

✓ Ravi and Meera have submitted **their** project.

Why: And = addition = plural.

✗ Neither the students nor the teacher raised **their** hand.

✓ Neither the students nor the teacher raised **her** hand.

Why: Nearer antecedent is the teacher — singular. (Stylists avoid this by putting the plural noun second: "Neither the teacher nor the students raised their hands.")

! GOLD TRAP

Each / every before a compound kills the plural: "**Every** boy and girl must bring **his or her** own pen" — not *their*. Each and every force you to take them one at a time, even with an *and*.

PART B · CASE — Who Is Doing, Who Is Receiving

RULE 7 — Subject forms act; object forms receive

Subjects: I, we, he, she, they, who. **Objects:** me, us, him, her, them, whom. The doer of the verb gets a subject form; the receiver of a verb or a preposition gets an object form. Errors hide in **compounds** — nobody says "Me went to class," but "Ravi and me went" slips past everyone.

✗ Ravi and **me** stayed back for the doubt session.

✓ Ravi and **I** stayed back for the doubt session.

Why: Drop the other person: "Me stayed back"? Never.

✗ This matter is strictly between you and **I**.

✓ This matter is strictly between you and **me**.

Why: Between is a preposition — object form follows. "Between you and I" sounds educated and is wrong; that is exactly why it appears in papers.

QUICK TEST: Drop-the-partner test. Delete the other person and say the sentence with just the pronoun. Your ear instantly knows "me went" and "gave I" are wrong.

RULE 8 — Comparisons with 'than' and 'as': finish the sentence in your head

After *than* or *as*, the sentence is usually amputated. Restore the missing verb and the right case appears by itself.

✗ My brother is taller than **me**.

✓ My brother is taller than **I** (am).

Why: Formal exam English completes the clause: *than I am*.

The meaning fork — sometimes both cases are grammatical and mean different things:

✓ She likes cricket more than **I**. (= more than I like cricket)

✓ She likes cricket more than **me**. (= more than she likes me)

Difference: Case changes the meaning, not just the formality. If a question hinges on this, read for sense first.

RULE 9 — We students / us students: delete the noun

When a pronoun and noun travel together (*we teachers, us Indians*), delete the noun and see which pronoun survives.

✗ **Us** aspirants must practise daily.

✓ **We** aspirants must practise daily.

Why: "Us must practise"? No — "We must practise."

✗ The institute felicitated **we** toppers.

✓ The institute felicitated **us** toppers.

Why: "Felicitated we"? No — "felicitated us."

RULE 10 — Possessive before an -ing noun (gerund)

When an -ing word works as a NOUN (a gerund), the pronoun before it must be possessive — because you possess the action.

✗ The teacher objected to **him** talking during the test.

✓ The teacher objected to **his** talking during the test.

Why: She objected to the TALKING (a thing), not to HIM (a person). The action is his — possessive.

✗ **Me** arriving late upset the invigilator.

✓ **My** arriving late upset the invigilator.

Why: The arriving is the subject — it needs an owner, not an object pronoun.

PART C · THE SELF FAMILY — Reflexives and Reciprocals

RULE 11 — Myself / himself / themselves: only when the doer and receiver are the same person

A reflexive pronoun (*myself, yourself, himself, herself, itself, ourselves, yourselves, themselves*) is legal in exactly two situations: (1) the subject and object are the SAME person, or (2) pure emphasis. It is **never** a polite replacement for I or me.

✗ Please submit the form to Ravi or **myself**.

✓ Please submit the form to Ravi or **me**.

Why: The subject is you (understood), not I — so myself has no partner in the sentence. "Myself" here is fake formality.

✗ My partner and **myself** designed the poster.

✓ My partner and **I** designed the poster.

Why: Same disease: myself cannot be a subject.

Legal uses: "She blamed **herself** for the error" (subject = object). "The director **himself** reviewed our file" (emphasis — removable without damage).

! GOLD TRAP

Watch for the missing partner. "The prize was shared between Arjun and **himself**" — himself has no matching subject in the sentence, so it must be **him**. A reflexive with no same-person subject in its own clause is always wrong.

RULE 12 — Each other (two) vs one another (three or more)

Classic exam convention: **each other** for exactly two parties, **one another** for three or more.

✗ The two finalists congratulated **one another**.

✓ The two finalists congratulated **each other**.

Why: Two parties → each other.

✗ The eleven players trust **each other** completely.

✓ The eleven players trust **one another** completely.

Why: More than two → one another.

Modern usage mixes these freely, but exam questions still test the traditional split — play it straight.

PART D · THE RELATIVE FAMILY — who, whom, whose, which, that, what

This is the heart of RV02 and the most-tested pronoun territory in IPMAT / JIPMAT. Six words, one job: connecting a describing clause to a noun. First meet the cast, then learn the four fights: which-vs-that, who-vs-that, who-vs-whom, and what-vs-that.

Pronoun	Points to	Role	Example
who	people	subject of its clause	the student who topped
whom	people	object of a verb / preposition	the mentor whom I trust
whose	people AND things	possession	a car whose engine failed
which	things, animals	subject or object; carries EXTRA info (with comma)	the CAT, which is online, ...
that	things AND people	subject or object; DEFINING info only (no comma)	the mock that I failed
what	= "the thing that"	carries its own antecedent — takes NO noun before it	What he said shocked us

RULE 13 — WHICH vs THAT — the comma rule (learn this cold)

Ask one question: **does the clause pick out WHICH one I mean, or just add extra information?**

• **Defining (restrictive)** — the clause is essential; remove it and you no longer know which thing is meant. Use **that**, and use **no commas**.

• **Non-defining (non-restrictive)** — the clause is bonus information; remove it and the sentence still identifies the thing. Use **which**, wrapped in **commas**.

✓ The answers **that were wrong** have been corrected. (only the wrong ones — the clause selects)

✓ The answers, **which were wrong**, have been corrected. (ALL the answers were wrong — the clause just comments)

Difference: Same words, one comma, completely different claim about how many answers were wrong. This meaning-shift is precisely what Hard-level questions test.

✗ My phone, **that** I bought last year, has stopped working.

✓ My phone, **which** I bought last year, has stopped working.

Why: **That** can never follow a comma. Comma → which. This is the fastest kill-rule in the whole guide.

✗ The test **which** I gave yesterday was tough. (exam English)

✓ The test **that** I gave yesterday was tough.

Why: No comma, defining clause → exam English prefers that. British writing tolerates defining which, but when both appear as options in a defining clause, pick that.

! GOLD TRAP

Two-second scan for any which/that question: **comma present** → **which**; **no comma and the clause identifies** → **that**. If choosing between two grammatically possible sentences, ask what the sentence MEANS to say — "only some" needs *that*, "all of them, by the way" needs comma + *which*.

RULE 14 — WHO vs THAT vs WHICH for people

Three sub-rules, in order of strictness:

1. **Which for a person is always wrong.** "The girl which won" — dead on arrival.
2. **Who is the formal choice for people.** "The girl who won." *That* for people ("the girl that won") is heard in speech and tolerated in defining clauses, but when *who* and *that* are both options for a human antecedent, exams reward **who**.
3. **Exception — THAT is preferred, even for people, after superlatives and all-or-nothing words:** *the best, the first, the last, the only, all, any, none, everything, nothing, the same*.

✗ She is the kindest teacher **which** I have met.

✓ She is the kindest teacher **that** I have met.

Why: Person → never which; superlative (kindest) → that beats who.

✗ All **which** glitters is not gold.

✓ All **that** glitters is not gold.

Why: After all / everything / nothing / none, the relative pronoun is that.

✗ My eldest brother, **that** works in Pune, is visiting.

✓ My eldest brother, **who** works in Pune, is visiting.

Why: Comma clause about a person → who (that can never follow a comma; which can never point to a person).

RULE 15 — WHO vs WHOM — the he/him test

Answer the clause's own question with *he* or *him*. If **he** fits → **who**. If **him** fits → **whom**. (Match the m's: **him** → **whom**.)

✗ The candidate **whom** topped the interview round was humble.

✓ The candidate **who** topped the interview round was humble.

Why: Who topped? HE topped → who. Whom placed as a subject is a favourite over-correction trap.

✗ The mentor **who** we consulted suggested a fresh mock.

✓ The mentor **whom** we consulted suggested a fresh mock.

Why: We consulted HIM → whom. Ignore the glamour of the main verb suggested; whom answers only to its own clause, we consulted ____.

! GOLD TRAP

The double-clause decoy: "Give the form to **whoever / whomever** asks for it." Your eye sees *to* and screams object → *whomever*. Wrong. The whole clause "whoever asks for it" is the object of *to*; INSIDE that clause, the pronoun is the subject of *asks* → **whoever**. Case is decided inside the pronoun's own clause, never by the word before it. Compare: "Invite **whomever** you like" — you like HIM → *whomever*.

RULE 16 — Prepositions with the relative family: to whom, in which — never 'in that'

A preposition can sit directly before **whom** and **which**, but never before **that** or **who**. If the preposition moves to the front, upgrade the pronoun.

✗ The professor **to who** I wrote has replied.

✓ The professor **to whom** I wrote has replied.

Why: Preposition in front → whom, never who.

✗ The hostel **in that** I stayed has been renovated.

✓ The hostel **in which** I stayed has been renovated. or The hostel **that** I stayed **in**...

Why: That refuses to follow a preposition. Either promote to *in which*, or send the preposition to the back with *that*.

The relative adverbs — where = in/at which (places), when = on/in which (times), why = for which (only after *reason*). They REPLACE the preposition; keeping both is a classic error:

✗ Ahmedabad is the city **where** I grew up **in**.

✓ Ahmedabad is the city **where** I grew up. or ...the city **in which** I grew up.

Why: Where already contains the *in*. Double preposition = double error.

RULE 17 — The verb inside the relative clause — the RV01 handshake

Who / which / that borrow their number from their antecedent, and the verb after them must follow it. The battlefield sentence is "one of the...":

✓ She is **one of the students who ARE** always prepared. (who → students; several students are prepared, she belongs to that group)

✓ She is **the only one of the students who IS** always prepared. (who → one; exactly one is prepared)

Difference: "The only" locks the antecedent onto one. Without it, the pronoun reaches back to the plural noun. This single pattern has produced Hard-level questions for a decade.

✗ He is one of those aspirants who **believes** in shortcuts.

✓ He is one of those aspirants who **believe** in shortcuts.

Why: who → aspirants (plural) → believe.

RULE 18 — WHAT and the missing pronoun

What = "the thing that." It carries its own antecedent inside it, so it can NEVER sit after a noun or after *all* — that seat already belongs to *that*.

✗ Revise all **what** we covered in class.

✓ Revise all **that** we covered in class. or Revise **what** we covered in class.

Why: All + what = two antecedents fighting for one chair. Pick one.

Dropping the relative pronoun is legal only when it is the OBJECT of its clause: "the mock (that) I attempted" ✓. When it is the subject, it cannot vanish:

✗ The student ____ scored 240 got a direct call.

✓ The student **who** scored 240 got a direct call.

Why: The pronoun is the subject of scored — subjects cannot be silently dropped.

PART E · CLEAR REFERENCE — The Invisible Errors

RULE 19 — One pronoun, one unmistakable antecedent

If a pronoun could point to two different nouns, the sentence is broken even though every individual word is grammatical. These errors are invisible to students who only check forms — you must check **meaning**.

✗ Ravi told Arjun that **he** had cleared the cut-off.

✓ Ravi told Arjun, "**You** have cleared the cut-off." or Ravi told Arjun that **Arjun** had cleared the cut-off.

Why: Who cleared — Ravi or Arjun? Ambiguous he. The fix always repeats the name or restructures; option-writers offer exactly such rewrites.

✗ Take the batteries out of the toys and recharge **them**.

✓ Take the batteries out of the toys and recharge **the batteries**.

Why: Them = batteries or toys? When both candidates are plural, the pronoun must go.

RULE 20 — Phantom antecedents: vague it / they / this / which

A pronoun needs a NOUN to hold on to. It cannot grab a whole sentence, an idea floating in the air, or a noun that never appeared.

✗ **They** say the Indore paper will be tougher this year.

✓ **Analysts** say the Indore paper will be tougher this year.

Why: Who are they? No antecedent exists — name the noun.

✗ He skipped the mock analysis, **which** was foolish.

✓ He skipped the mock analysis, **a decision that** was foolish. or Skipping the mock analysis was foolish.

Why: This which points at the whole act, not a noun. Formal exam rewrites give the idea its own noun (a decision, a habit, a move).

✗ In the notice, **it** mentions the revised timings.

✓ The notice mentions the revised timings.

Why: Empty it with the real subject hiding inside a prepositional phrase — promote the noun.

RULE 21 — A pronoun cannot reach inside a possessive

A possessive (*Kalidasa's*, *the college's*) works as an adjective — and pronouns cannot refer to adjectives. The person hiding inside the apostrophe is grammatically invisible.

✗ In **Premchand's** stories, **he** portrays rural India honestly.

✓ In his stories, **Premchand** portrays rural India honestly.

Why: He tries to grab Premchand's — an adjective. Flip the sentence so the name stands free.

RULE 22 — No person-shifting mid-sentence

Start in one person, finish in the same person. The favourite exam version: a sentence begins with a *student / one / anyone* (third person) and drifts into *you* (second person).

✗ If a candidate manages time well, **you** can attempt all sections.

✓ If a candidate manages time well, **he or she** can attempt all sections.

Why: Started with a candidate — stay third person.

✗ **One** must revise **his** notes daily. (*British convention*)

✓ **One** must revise **one's** notes daily.

Why: In the one...one's vs one...his fight, Indian exams follow the British line: one → one's. (American style permits his; if both options appear, prefer one's.)

! GOLD TRAP

The spelling impostors — not agreement errors, but planted beside them to waste your time: **its** (possessive) vs **it's** (= it is); **whose** (possessive) vs **who's** (= who is); **their** (possessive) vs **there** (place) vs **they're** (= they are). Test: expand the apostrophe. "The team lost it's way" → "lost it is way"? Absurd → its.

ONE-PAGE REVISION TABLE — the whole guide in 60 seconds

#	If you see...	Remember...
1	any pronoun	find the antecedent FIRST; copy its number, person, gender
2	each, either, neither, everyone, anybody, one...	always singular — ignore the of-phrase after it
3	both, few, many, several	always plural
4	some / any / none / all / most + of	chameleon — agree with the noun after of; none: prefer singular
5	team, committee, jury, family	one unit → its; separate members → their; never mix mid-sentence
6	A and B / A or B	and → their; or/nor → match the NEARER one; each/every + and → singular
7	Ravi and I / me	drop the partner and listen; between you and ME (always)
8	than / as + pronoun	finish the clause: taller than I (am); watch the meaning fork
9	we / us + noun	delete the noun: We aspirants work; it helped us aspirants
10	pronoun + -ing noun	possessive before a gerund: objected to HIS talking
11	myself / himself...	only if subject = object, or pure emphasis; NEVER replaces I / me
12	each other / one another	two → each other; three or more → one another
13	which vs that	comma → which (extra info); no comma + defining → that; comma + that = always wrong
14	person antecedent	who (formal); never which; after best/first/only/all → that
15	who vs whom	answer with he → who; him → whom; whoever/whomever: decide INSIDE its own clause
16	preposition + relative	to whom, in which — never to who, in that; where/when/why swallow the preposition
17	one of the Xs who...	verb agrees with Xs (plural); THE ONLY one of the Xs who → singular
18	what	= the thing that; never after a noun or all (all THAT glitters)
19	he/she/it/they with 2 candidates	ambiguous reference — the pronoun must have exactly one home
20	they say / it mentions / , which	phantom antecedent — a pronoun cannot point at thin air or a whole clause
21	In X's book, he...	pronouns cannot refer to possessives — free the name
22	a student ... you	no person shift; one → one's (British / exam line)

SPOT CHECK — 10 sentences before you touch the tests

Choose the correct option in each sentence. They get harder as you go — exactly like the test ladder will. Write your answers down BEFORE looking at the key.

1. Each of the girls finished (her / their) project on time.
2. Ravi and (I / me) stayed back after the Verbal class.
3. The committee announced (its / their) decision in a single joint statement.
4. This is the house (that / which) Jack built.
5. My cousin, (that / who / which) lives in Pune, is visiting us next week.
6. The teacher praised the students (who / whom) she had personally trained.
7. Neither the players nor the coach has submitted (his / their) fitness report.
8. She is one of those students who (is / are) always prepared for a surprise quiz.
9. Give the extra ticket to (whoever / whomever) reaches the gate first.
10. The principal objected to (him / his) leaving the seminar midway.

ANSWER KEY — check only after attempting all ten

#	Answer	One-line reason
1	her	each = always singular; "of the girls" is a decoy (Rule 2)
2	I	drop the partner: "I stayed back" (Rule 7)
3	its	"single joint statement" = acting as one unit (Rule 5)
4	that	defining clause, no comma (Rule 13)
5	who	comma clause about a person: that is barred by the comma, which is barred by the person (Rules 13–14)
6	whom	she had trained THEM → object (Rule 15)
7	his	nor → agree with the nearer antecedent, the coach (Rule 6)
8	are	who reaches back to students, plural — no "the only" here (Rule 17)
9	whoever	subject of "reaches"; the to governs the whole clause, not the pronoun (Rule 15)
10	his	possessive before the gerund "leaving" (Rule 10)

READINESS RULE

8–10 correct: You are ready — start RV02 Easy today. **6–7 correct:** Reread only the rules named against your wrong answers, then start Easy. **5 or fewer:** Read the full guide once more tomorrow with fresh eyes before testing. The ladder rewards honest entry — 70%+ unlocks the next level, below 50% sends you back here.